



Figure 1: FOSS applications for which trained professionals are in demand
(Courtesy: OSSCube)

by the day and will not spend unnecessarily on proprietary software when better quality FOSS is available and readily downloadable from the Internet. FOSS professionals will be the ones enabling organisations benefit from the cost savings provided."

Adding to this view, Rajesh Chhikara, director of the Institute of Open Source, and head of HR, EarlySail Software, says: "It's very simple—if you need to be different from the crowd then you have to learn technology that you have not learnt in college and the best way is to opt for open source technologies. Open source technologies guarantee that you leap ahead of the crowd."

With an increasing number of businesses lowering internal costs using FOSS, FOSS experts are sure to play an integral part in the process. "Trained and certified FOSS IT professionals can help the organisation take the right decision and this increases their chances to rise up the corporate ladder, faster," testifies Mitul Limbani, founder and CEO, Enterux Solutions.

Further, expertise in FOSS is bound to help you score over your proprietary software counterparts. "The 'thinking horizon' of a FOSS expert is wider than that of a proprietary software expert. FOSS experts deal with a lot of logical and environment compatibility challenges that makes them naturally more dynamic. Further, they are more proficient in building Web- and mobile-based applications than proprietary software experts," says Sonali Minocha, director, training, OSSCube. "The confidence to tweak and tune with the open source product gives FOSS experts a competitive edge over proprietary software experts as they can customise software as per one's need and at a cheaper cost," says Shankar Iyer, director, Red Hat. FOSS experts also have the benefit of support from a much larger online community for any problem that crops up.

The skillsets in demand

Thus, every sector, whether it is Web development or product development; human resources, financial applications or charting analysis, is yearning for open

Hungry kya, for FOSS experts?



The recession-led cutback on IT spends has given a huge boost to the demand for FOSS experts. That, coupled with changes in the IT landscape like independent software vendors drifting towards open source, SMEs plugging into FOSS sockets, and the reliance on FOSS in the embedded device, mobile and netbook space, has further fostered the hunger for FOSS experts. "Most SMEs, as well as major enterprises across the globe, have reduced IT spending during the recession. Further, clients have been asking the software development companies to develop the required solutions on open source," says Gopal S, CEO, Nace Solutions.

The embedded device space, especially related to mobiles and netbooks, has contributed to the demand for FOSS experts. "Acer uses the Moblin OS in its netbooks, so does BenQ's new S6 MID. There is a lot of FOSS development in the Blackberry area, like the GPS logger, which can help you log GPS plots every second. Now, open source Telnet/SSH clients are available for mobile devices also. This has resulted in the demand for professionals to be trained in open source technologies to help this industry make better products, cheaper and faster," explains Rajesh Chhikara, director of the Institute of Open Source, and head of HR, EarlySail Software.

Talking about other catalysts fuelling the demand for FOSS experts, Sonali Minocha, director, training, OSSCube, says: "Today, mobile and Web application technologies are heavily FOSS focused. The enterprise-class FOSS applications available in the market too are giving good competition to the proprietary software companies. Lastly, governments worldwide have passed legislations or given preference to open source, which has been a huge boost to FOSS."

The maturing FOSS industry, too, has contributed to the growth of FOSS and the subsequent demand for experts. "The increasing awareness of FOSS and better availability of systems administrators who have knowledge of FOSS, has led to more companies adopting it. This has caused a spurt in demand for FOSS experts," says J A Bhavsar, group head, ITM Business School. Adding to this, Satish Gopinath, proprietor, Integer Education, says: "There is a clear movement towards FOSS among the IT community. The movement has been fostered by a general maturing of FOSS products and the availability of support."

source experts. But for a smooth take off of your FOSS career, it is important to first have the skillsets in demand.

A FOSS professional can basically follow one of the following two paths—development or administration. "Professionals with expertise in security dataware housing, MySQL DBA and FOSS-based infrastructure management software; certified FOSS professionals, Zend Framework/Symfony Framework engineers, and Drupal developers